

OPENING

How a text chooses to begin



1 What is it?

Opening

The opening is how a writer **chooses to begin** a text — the very first thing a reader sees sets expectations, grabs attention, and can hint at what's coming.

first lines = first impression

2 See it in action

In medias res

Starting mid-action, dropping the reader straight into a chase or an argument.

A striking image

Opening on a single vivid, unusual picture the reader can't forget.

Direct address

Speaking straight to the reader — "You won't believe what happened next."

Quiet and ordinary

Starting calm and everyday, so a later disruption feels more shocking.



Mfalme says...

Ask yourself: **what does the opening make me expect** about the rest of the text — genre, mood, main character? That expectation is exactly what the writer is playing with.

FUN FACT

Many exam-winning openings deliberately withhold information — starting with a question the reader can't yet answer is one of the oldest tricks for forcing someone to keep reading.

3 Why writers use it

Opening helps writers: hook the reader immediately, establish tone and genre before anything else happens, and plant a question or image that pulls them into the rest of the text.

A strong opening does double duty — it grabs attention AND quietly sets up an idea (a word, an image, a question) that the writer will return to later.

4 Don't mix it up!

Opening

- The **very first** lines/paragraph
- Sets tone and **expectations**
- Grabs attention immediately

Ending

- The **final** lines/paragraph
- Leaves a **lasting impression**
- Often echoes the opening



Watch out!

Don't just describe WHAT happens in the opening — analyse WHY the writer chose to start there. What effect does that specific choice create for the reader?



Look here!

Check whether the ending **echoes or contrasts** with the opening — a "cyclical" link between the two is a top-mark observation.

5 Quick recap

The text's first lines

Sets tone and expectations

Hooks the reader in



You got this!

Try writing three different openings for the same story — one action-packed, one calm, one a direct question to the reader. Notice how differently each one feels.